

The only way out of this mess was to claim the deal never happened, or that Owl had misheard me as having said 50,000 when I had actually said 500. But there were witnesses to our trade; Owl had ensured that. If I backed out of the deal, my reputation would take a knock and others would become less trustful of me.

Another option was to grovel before Owl and request him to cancel the trade. But my pride would not allow that. And even if I did plead with him, he would first savour my discomfort and then still refuse me. If I stood by the deal, there was a high probability of my having to take a loss beyond my capacity. Every one rupee of loss meant I would be out of pocket by Rs 50,000.

I was sure that Owl was fronting for his masters, who seemed determined to force me out of this profession in disgrace. As of now, they had won half the battle.

The settlement was about a week away, and even if I did manage to get out of my position in Apollo Tyres, it was likely to be at a loss. Knowing AS-PS's hatred for me, they would spread the word that I was desperate to offload 50,000 shares of Apollo Tyres. Anybody looking to buy from me would then try to beat me down on the price. I had nobody to blame for this situation but myself.

Later that day I bumped into AS as I was leaving the ring for my office.

'I understand you have a big lot of Apollo Tyres to sell. Can I be of help?' he asked with mock seriousness.

I tried to ignore him, but PS did not give up so easily.

'Well, Lala, we warned you enough times not to play around with us. And I had promised you that I would make you pay. I hope you have already thought of an alternative profession for after next week,' he said as he went away.

My situation appeared to be beyond salvage. I tried to picture various scenarios. The best-case scenario would be my making a fat profit on the trade. The chances of that looked next to impossible, especially since my foes would have spread the word that there was a desperate seller hawking 50,000 shares. The next-best scenario was to get out of the position at no-profit-no-loss, but with a lesson learnt in humility. The chances of that too appeared slim. A loss of even one rupee per share would be painful, but I could still prevail on my boss to keep me in the job and work off my debt. A loss of two rupees, and I could not be sure of my job, though I could still